

Desert tortoise

Has shovel-shaped forefeet that help it dig burrows, where it shelters from the extreme heat of the day and the cold of the night.

Mesquite

tree with a long taproot that can grow up to 190 ft (60 m) long, as it searches for water deep underground.

Caribou

A deer specialized in living in the cold, high Arctic. Although it experiences the low rainfall of a desert, there is rarely a water shortage, because water collects in pools above the deeply frozen soil. There is no hot sun to dry it up.

Greenland ice sheet

This region experiences the coldest and driest conditions in the Arctic. Nothing can live on top of the ice.

Great Basin USA

Mojave Desert US

Sonoran Desert US and Mexico

Saguaro cactus

Tall, tree-like cactus that grows in the Sonoran Desert. Survives by storing water in its fleshy trunk and stems when it rains. It lives off this water until the rains come again.

Patagonian Desert, Argentina

Some experts call this a dry grassland rather than a desert.

Chihuahuan Desert Northern Mexico

Spadefoot toad

Digs a burrow with spadelike ridges on its back feet. It then makes a watertight cocoon of shed skin and waits—sometimes for months—for the next rains to fall.

Sechura Desert Peru

Atacama Desert, Chile

Like the Namib, this is a coastal desert, kept dry by a cold ocean current nearby.

Almería, Spain

Europe's driest region is true desert in parts.

Dromedary camel

Native to Arabia but lives throughout deserts of north Africa. Can live on fat stored in its hump and survives for 2 weeks without a drink.

Syrian Desert

Negev Desert

Sahara

Sahel

A belt of semidesert, also known as arid savanna, or dry grassland.

Tsamma watermelon

Wild ancestor of the watermelon. Grows in the Kalahari Desert and stores water in its big, round fruits.

Lithops, or "living stones"

Plants also known as pebble plants, because their single pair of round leaves looks like stones, camouflaging them against grazers. The leaves also help the plants to save and store water.

Namib desert beetle

Collects minute droplets of water from early-morning fog on its legs and hard wing cases. When enough water forms, a droplet rolls down the beetle's body into its mouth.

Namib Desert Namibia

Kalahari Desert Botswana and South Africa

Deserts

Deserts are found from the icy poles to the tropics. So while all deserts have low rainfall—less than 10 in (250 mm) a year, and often much less—they are not always hot. Even in hot deserts, the nights are often cold.

Antarctica

One of the most arid parts of Earth's largest desert is its Dry Valleys region (right), the only area of Antarctica not covered in thick ice, and where there is almost no snowfall. Cold, dry winds blast down from mountain peaks and turn all moisture to water vapor.